



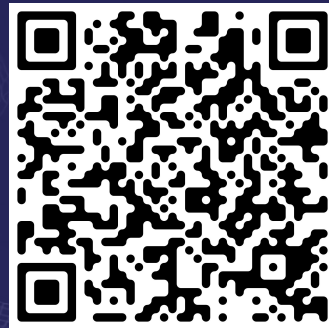
RESEARCH
ON RESEARCH
INSTITUTE

Distributed Peer Review at the Volkswagen Foundation

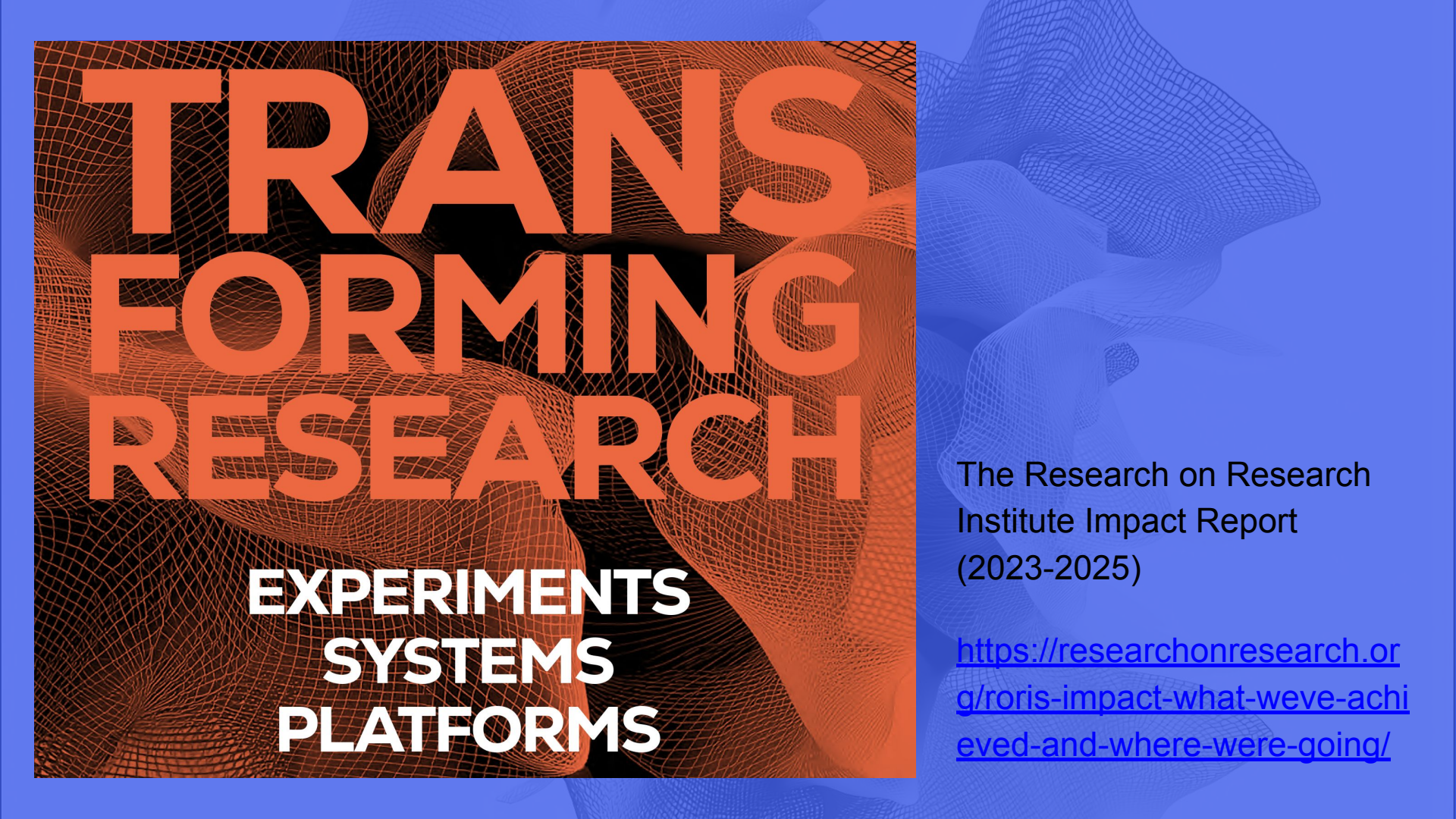
Tom Stafford, Anna Butters, Melanie Benson Marshall, & Stephen Pinfield
(Research on Research Institute and University of Sheffield)

Hanna Denecke, Alexander Bondarenko, Robert Nuske & Pierre Schwidlinski
(Volkswagen Foundation)

28/09/2026



These slides:
bit.ly/tomstafford



TRANSFORMING RESEARCH

EXPERIMENTS
SYSTEMS
PLATFORMS

The Research on Research
Institute Impact Report
(2023-2025)

<https://researchonresearch.org/roris-impact-what-weve-achieved-and-where-were-going/>

Accelerator For Innovation & Research Funding Experimentation (AFIRE)

1. Awareness
2. Motivation
3. Capacity
4. Scale and reach
5. The culture

<https://researchonresearch.org/project/a-f-i-r-e/>

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FORUM

Sharing work by funders, for funders. Building global awareness and initial motivation to experiment.

CAPACITY BUILDING

Sprints on AI/ML in reviewer selection. Equipping funding institutions with execution frameworks.

EXPERIMENTS

Distributed Peer Review, Partial Randomisation, Desk Rejection, and robust quantitative pilots.

AFIRE | 2024-25 Funder Forum Series



Villum Experiment – a grant scheme with double-blind evaluation

Anders Smith, Villum Foundation

Predicting Progress: A Pilot of Expected Utility Forecasting in Science Funding

Alice Wu, Federation of American Scientists & Jordan Dworkin, Open Philanthropy

Enhancing EDI in application processes in the CES Transformation Fund

Rachel Kendal, Principal Investigator CES Transformation Fund

Partial Randomisation at The British Academy

Ken Emond, The British Academy & Adrian Barnett, Queensland University of Technology

Do Grant Proposal Texts Matter for Funding Decisions? A Field Experiment at NWO

Müge Şimşek, University of Amsterdam

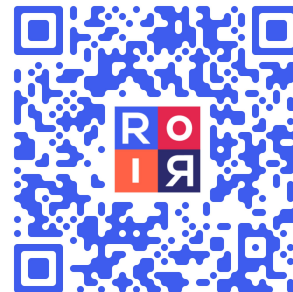
An experiment with Distributed Peer Review

Hanna Denecke, The Volkswagen Foundation

Two-stage versus continuous application processing

Jan-Ole Hesselberg, Stiftelsen Dam

Recordings



[https://www.youtube.com/
@researchonresearchinstitut6175](https://www.youtube.com/@researchonresearchinstitut6175)

FORUM | Experimental Funders Group, 2026

Shorter talks, more time for discussion

13 May 16:00 CEST

AI in Funding

17 June 16:00 CEST

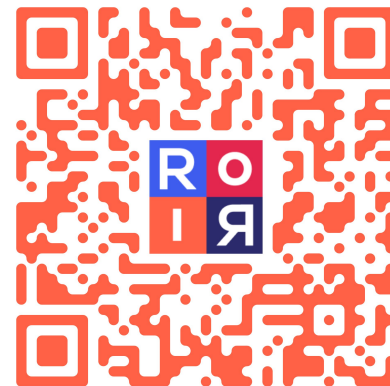
Distributed Peer Review

16 December 09:00 CEST

'Lottery First' methods

24 February 16:00 CEST

Desk Rejection



<https://forms.gle/TV9DdsAHHP5aUDHN7>

OUR DEFINITION OF EXPERIMENT

Principled

A research design that allows inference about what causes what (before/after, shadow experiments, true experiment/RCT).

Planned

Primary outcome measure and analysis plan declared in advance.

Public

A commitment to sharing the results regardless of outcome.

DPR experiments at The Volkswagen Foundation



- Applicants review other applications submitted for the same funding call
- “Open Up” programme – interdisciplinary projects, focus on innovation in the Humanities and Social Sciences
- Parallel implementation of DPR and established panel review process
- Additional funding provided: funding recommendations from both panel review and DPR
- Mixed methods evaluation: quantitative analysis of data from submissions and surveys of applicants, and qualitative interviews with a sample of applicants and other stakeholders
- Rich datasets to gain insight into dynamics of grant peer review e.g.:
 - Comparisons between review processes
 - Reviewer uncertainty
 - Consistency between reviewers
 - Stability of funding decision
 - Attitudes of actors

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First DPR experiment

- 2024 'Open Up' call
- 'Live' funding experiment
- Wide interest in and dissemination of results:
 - RoRI working paper
 - RoRI insights guide
 - Journal article
 - Metascience 25, ICSSI

DPR 2.0



- Experiment repeated in 2025
- Minor changes to the call and procedure
- Evaluation extended
 - Interviews with other funders
- Comparison across years
- New outputs!

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Distributed Peer Review and Panel Review Process – Parallel Processes

Panel review process



Proposals submitted

2024: 140
2025: 161

DPR



Distributed Peer Review and Panel Review Process – Parallel Processes

Panel review process



Proposals submitted

2024: 140
2025: 161

Per proposal: overall score, scores for each criteria & comment (DPR only), scientific evaluation questions

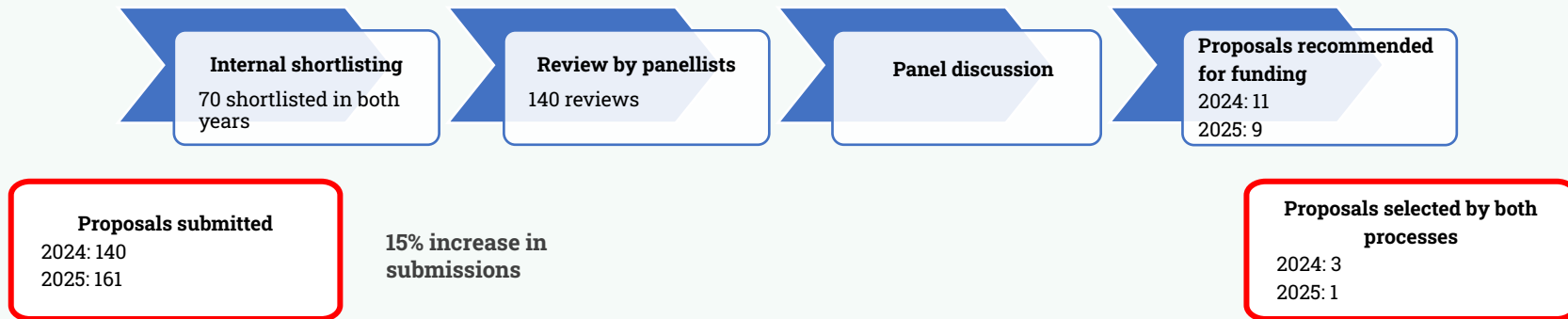
Four funding criteria; exploratory nature & novelty, added value of the constellation (multi-perspective approach), originality, scientific quality

DPR



18 proposals funded in each year

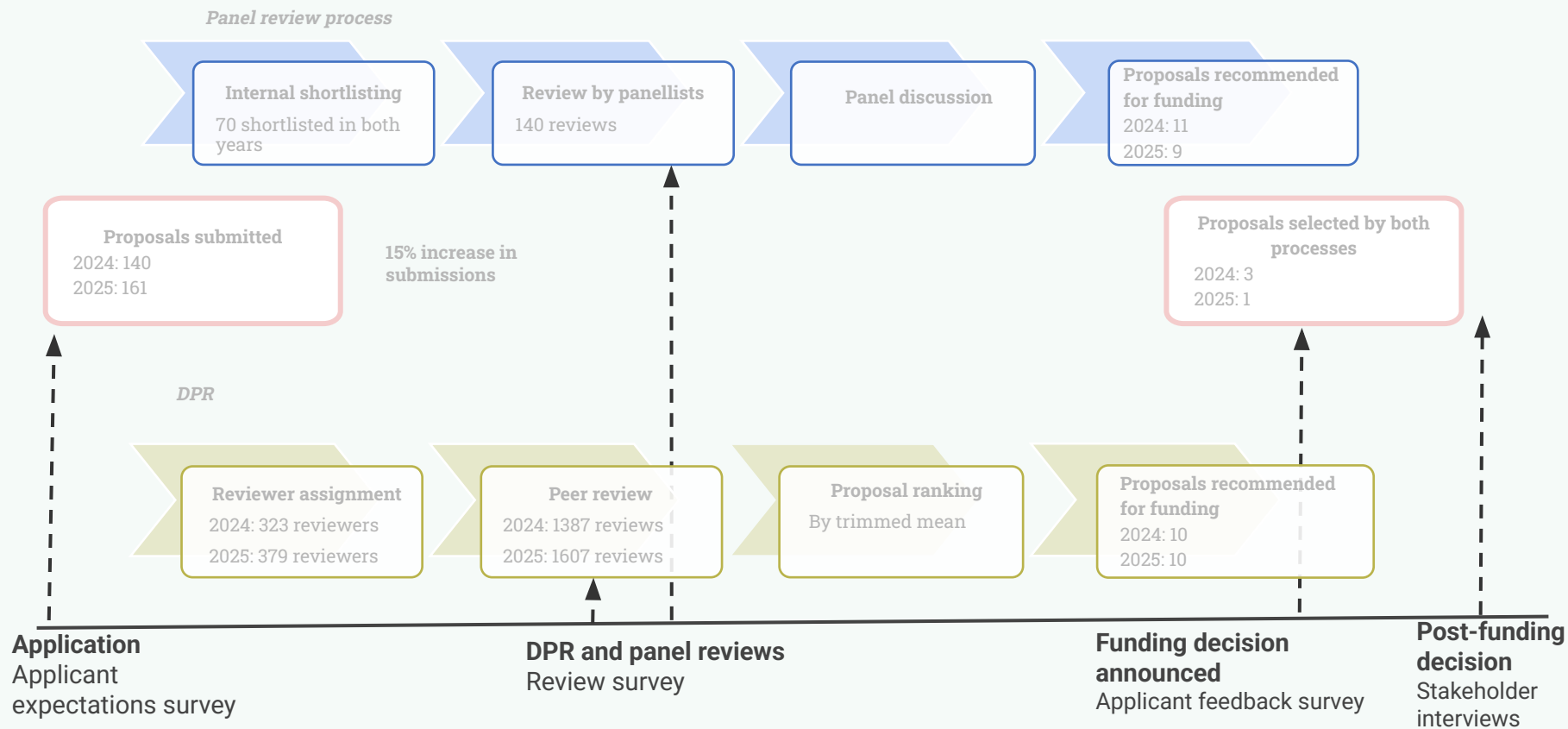
Panel review process



DPR

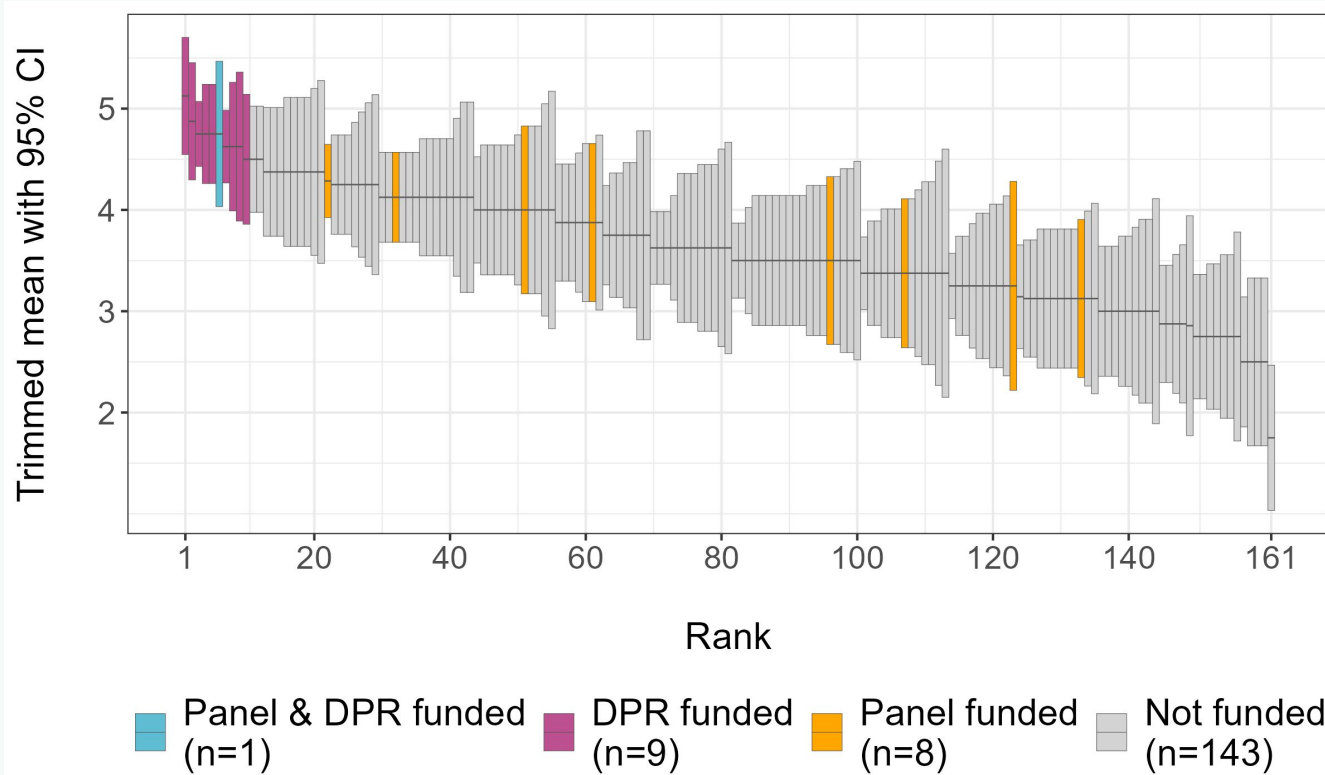


Data collected at multiple timepoints: application, on review, funding decision



Comparing DPR and panel funding decisions

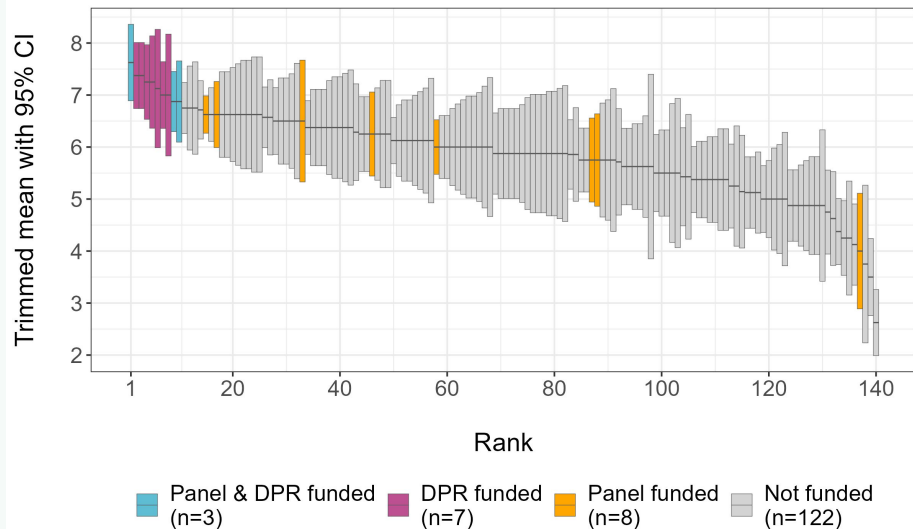
Panel selected proposals are found across the full range of DPR scores



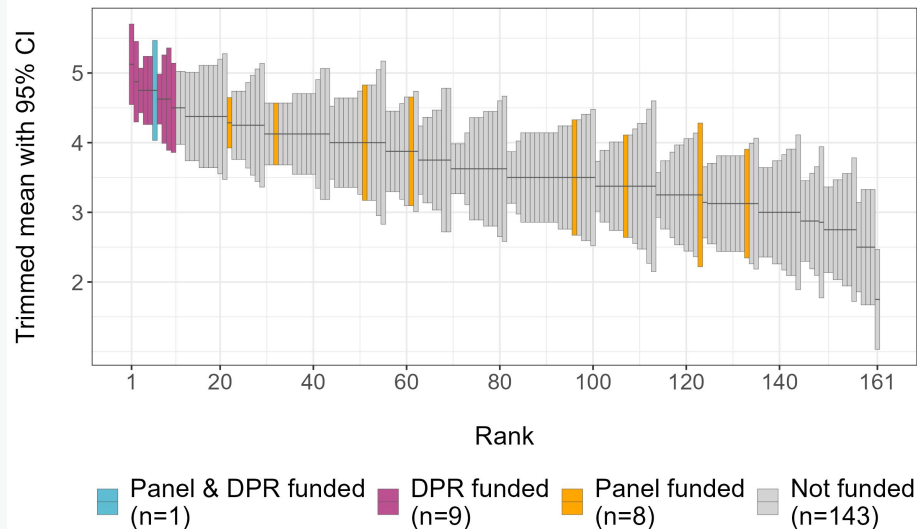
2025

Overlap was lower in 2025, but **consistent with the same level of agreement as 2024**

2024

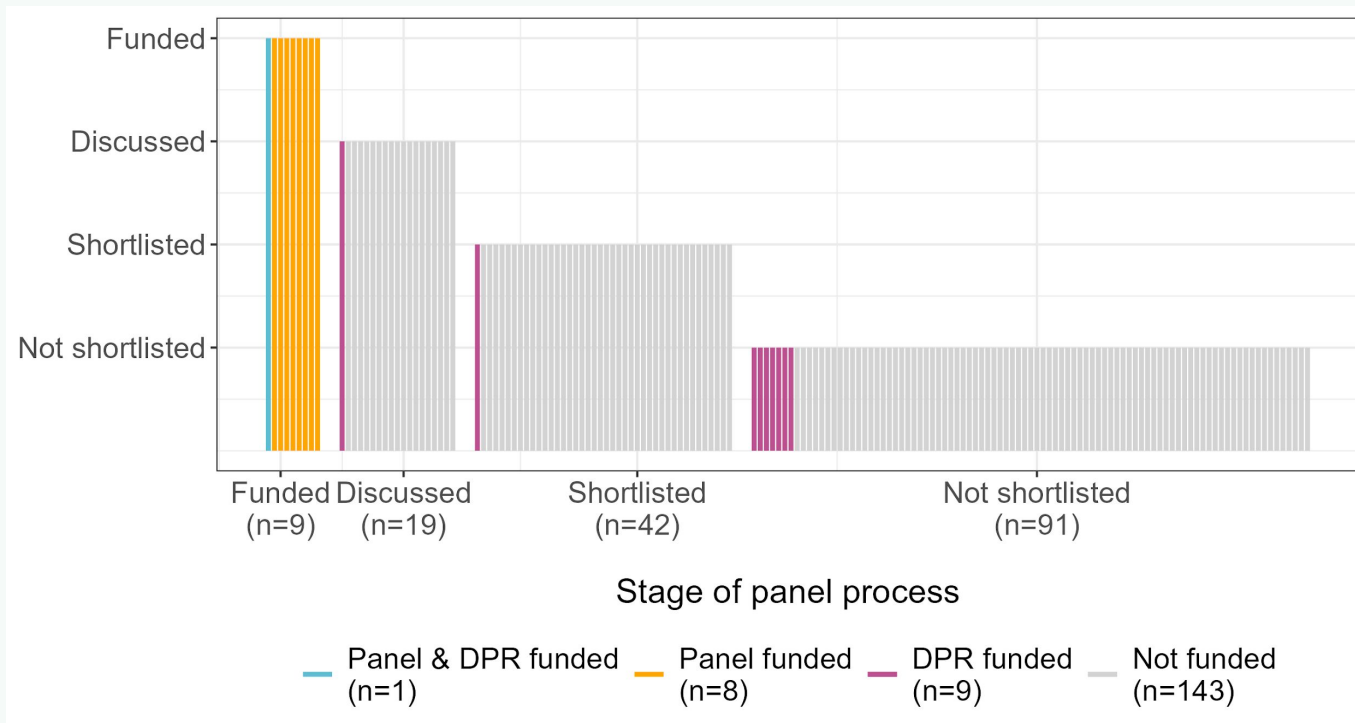


2025



Panel selected proposals are found across the full range of DPR scores

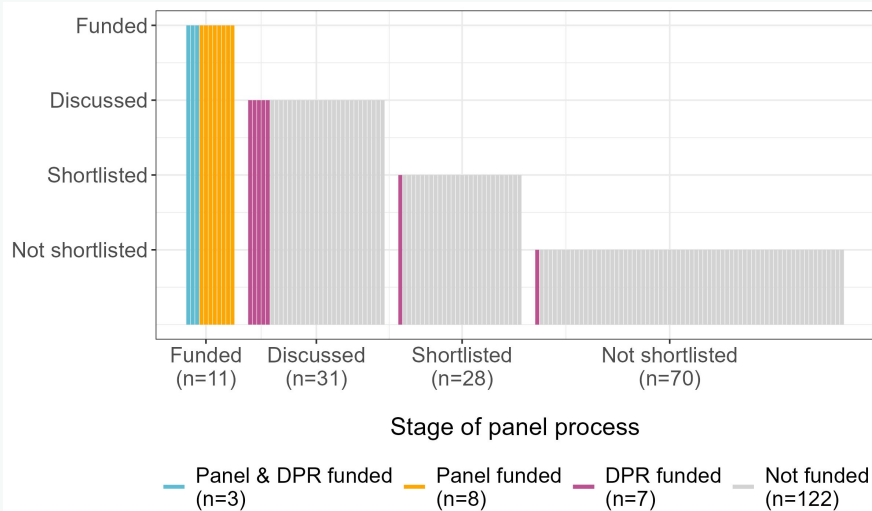
2025



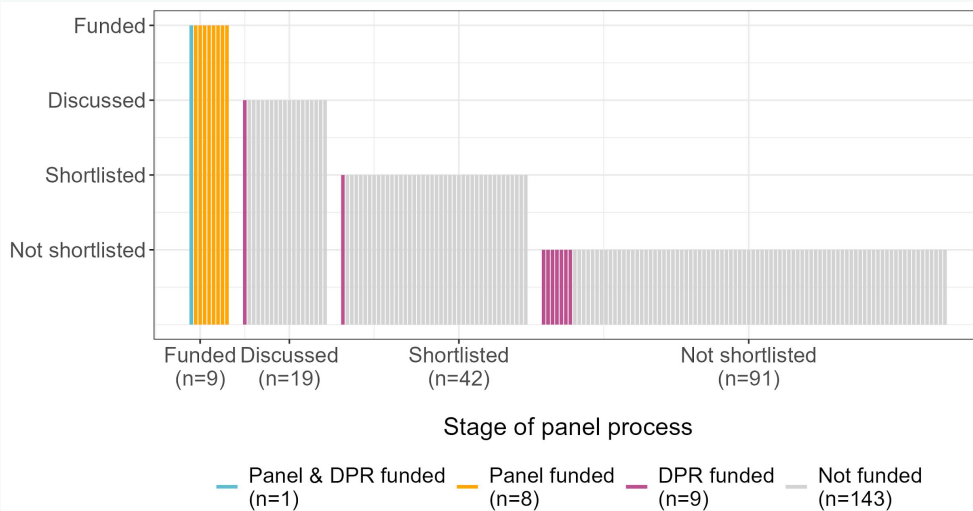
More DPR funded proposals were shortlisted in the panel process in 2024



2024

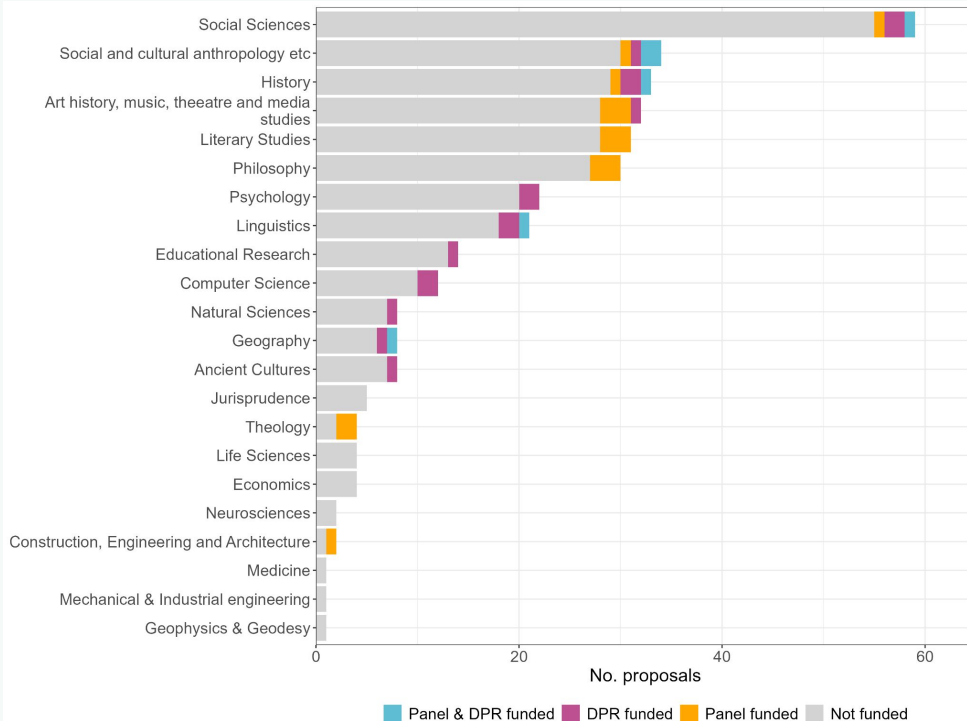


2025

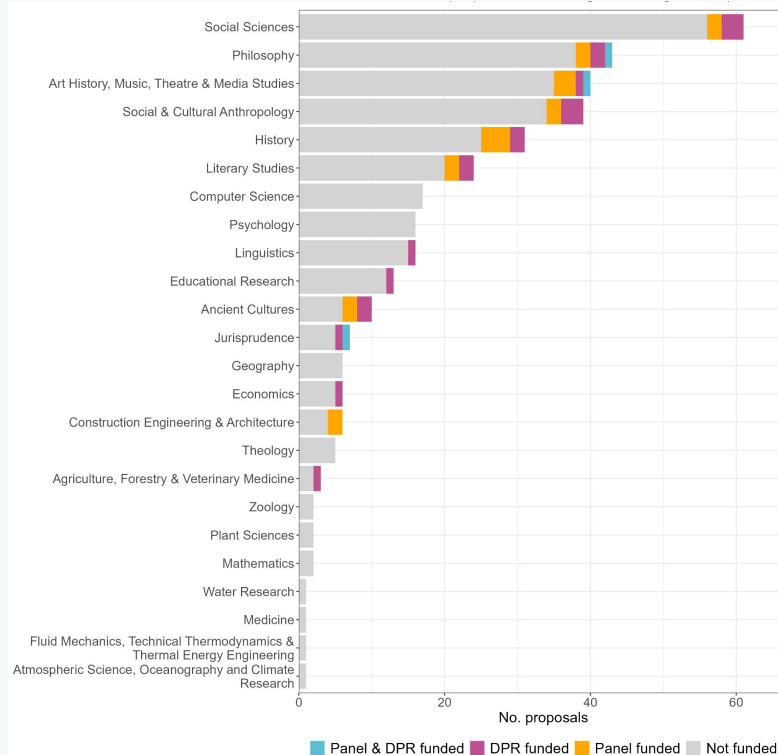


DPR funded proposals spanned slightly more unique disciplines

2024



2025



Expectations and experience of DPR: What do stakeholders think?

Applicant expectations were consistently fairly positive



Applicant characteristics were similar in both years:

- ~ 47% identified as female
- ~ 35% first generation university student
- Working in research for, on average, 14.5 years

Before participation:

- Over 73% believed DPR was **fair**
- Over 76% thought it would **identify appropriate reviewers**
- Around 85% believed it was **suitable** to assess their proposal
- Over 72% believed it would **select the best** proposals
- Over 68% thought DPR would **select more adventurous** proposals
- **Less than 50%** expected **DPR and panel to select similar set of proposals**

But also some concerns:

- **Additional workload**
- **Insufficient expertise**
- **'Gaming'**

Feedback was also fairly positive



Optional feedback surveys:

- 127 applicants (39.3%) in 2024
- 91 applicants (24%) in 2025

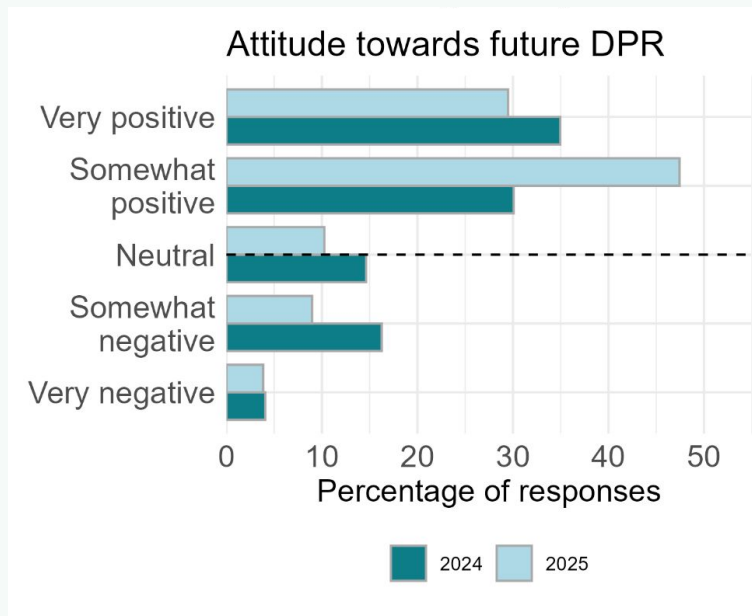
Over 63% of review comments considered constructive

Most *funded* respondents positive about taking part in DPR in future

(2024 = 82.8%, 2025 = 94.5%)

Many *unfunded* respondents also positive

(2024 = 59.6%, 2025 = 71.7%)



Feedback comments and stakeholder interviews revealed benefits & disadvantages

Benefits

More efficient and can shorten time to decision.

More (diverse) feedback

Addresses issues of reviewer recruitment

Educational

Enjoyable/interesting process

Fairer/more democratic



Disadvantages

Increased burden for applicants

Gaming

No opportunity for discussion/clarification

Reviewers lack experience or expertise

Reviewer experience & expertise

Minor differences in review comments according to career stage

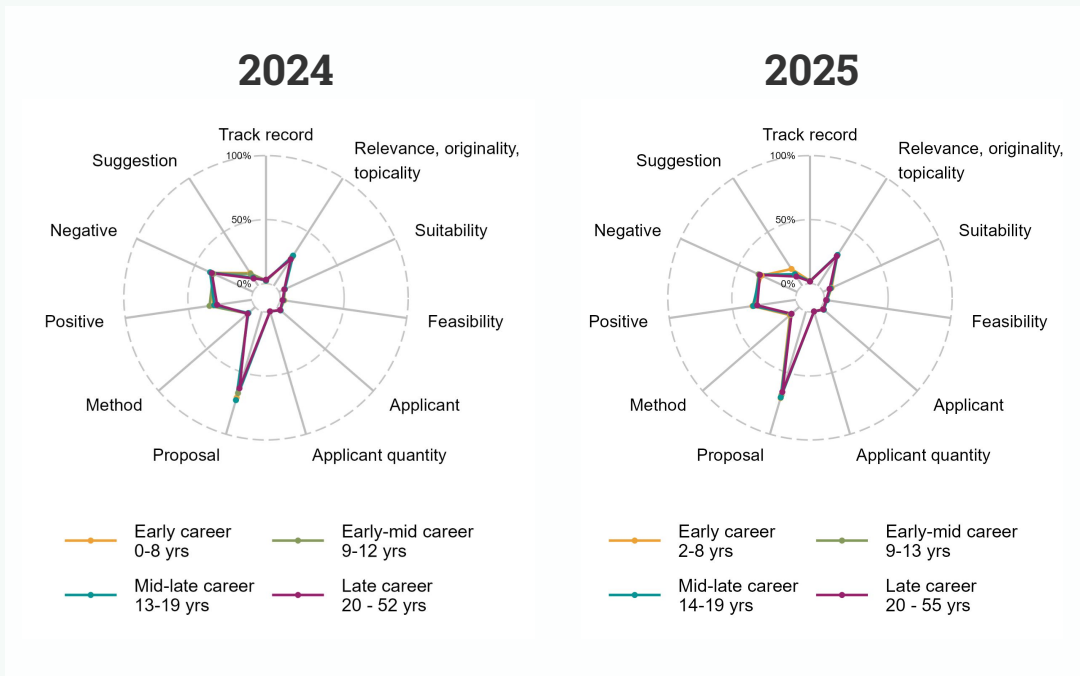
Automated analysis of review comments from 2024 and 2025

Content categories and sentiment per sentence

E.g. *'Does the sentence address the feasibility of the proposed research project?'*

Prevalence per comment and on average

Minor variation in comment content/sentiment; small effects



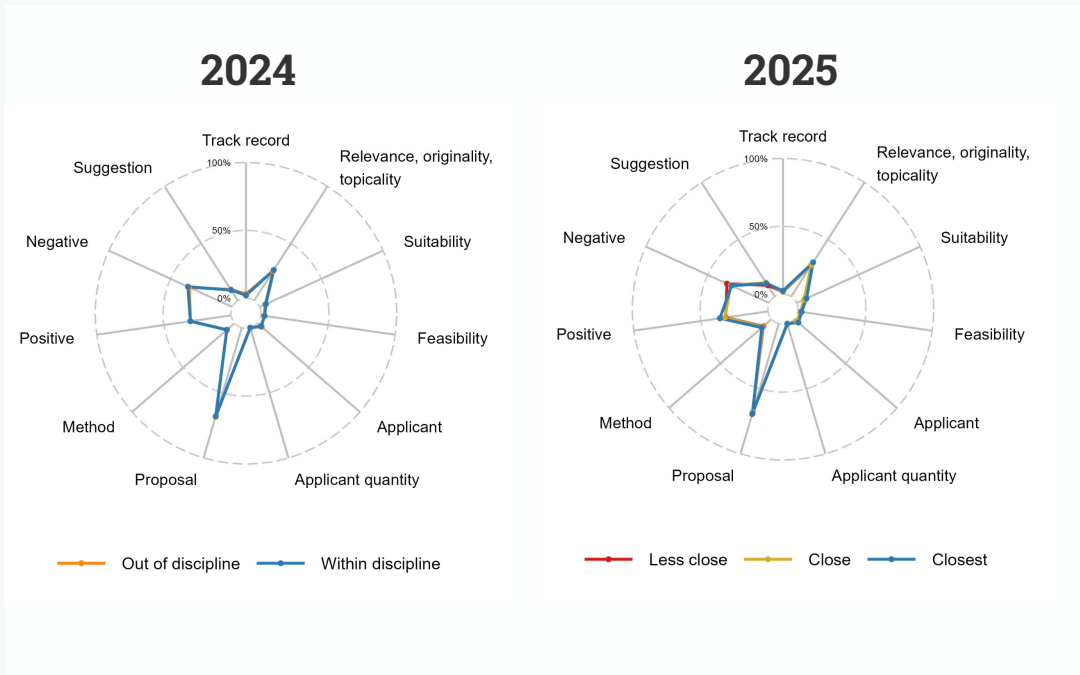
Minimal differences according to disciplinary alignment

Alignment between applicant disciplinary expertise and proposal under review:

2024: **within/ outside of discipline**

2025: **disciplinary closeness**
(less close/close/closest)

Minimal differences in content/sentiment of comments or scores awarded according to disciplinary alignment



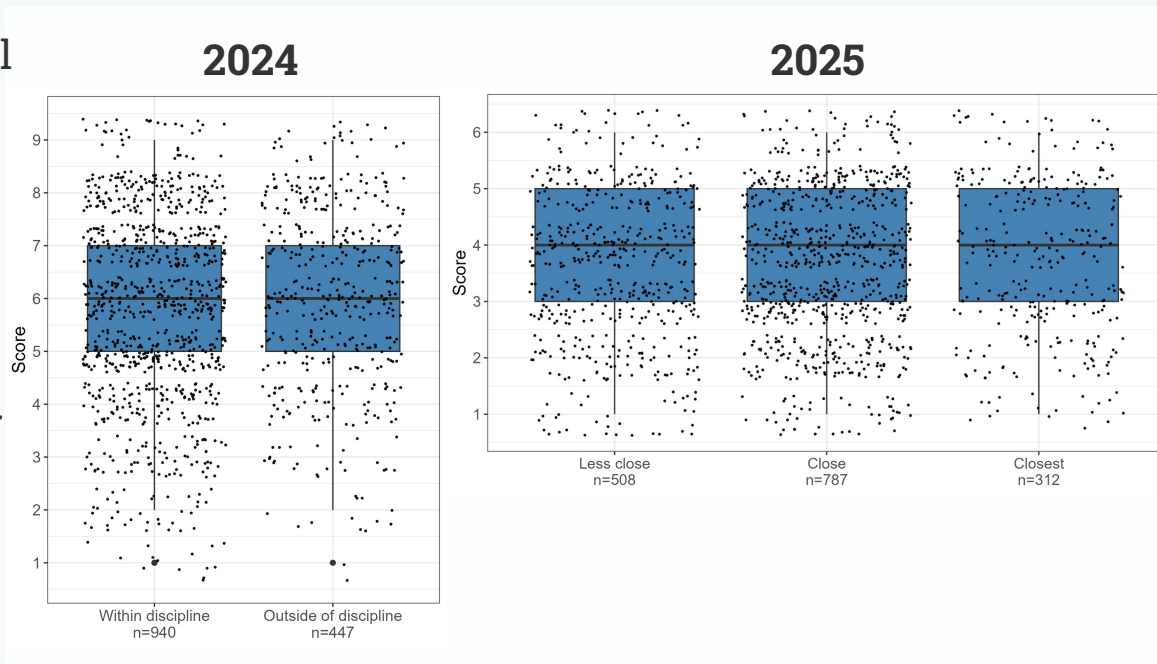
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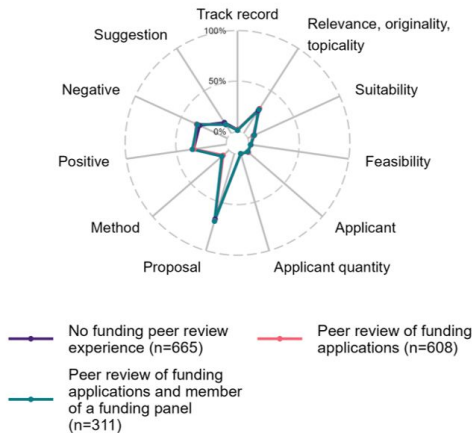
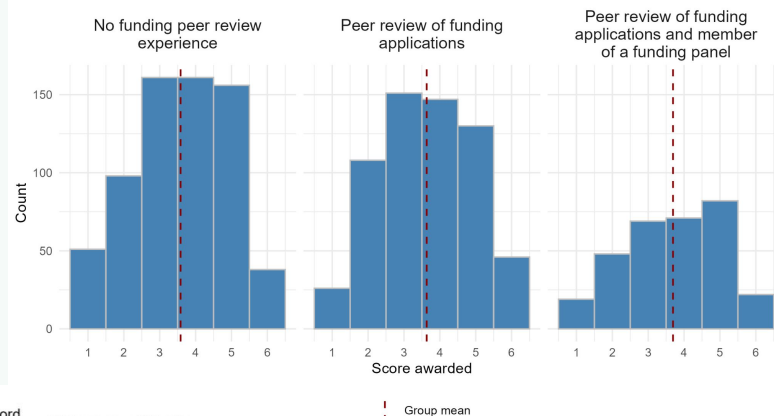
Minimal differences according to previous reviewing experience

60% of applicants had previous experience of *funding* peer review

No significant difference in average scores awarded; the most experienced applicant-reviewers tended to award slightly higher scores

Minimal differences in comment content and sentiment

Distribution of scores awarded according to review experience



Findings so far...



- Many findings consistent across both years; others only partially consistent
- Some overlap between DPR and panel decisions but also divergence in processes and selected proposals
- DPR increases the total time spent reviewing but this is distributed more equally between more people
- Modest stability of funding decisions, potentially due to inter-reviewer variability; trimming helps
- No evidence that less experienced or more disciplinary distant reviewers are 'worse' reviewers
- Suggested benefits: faster time to decision, 'democratisation' of funding evaluation
- Common concerns: applicant workload, 'gaming', reviewer expertise

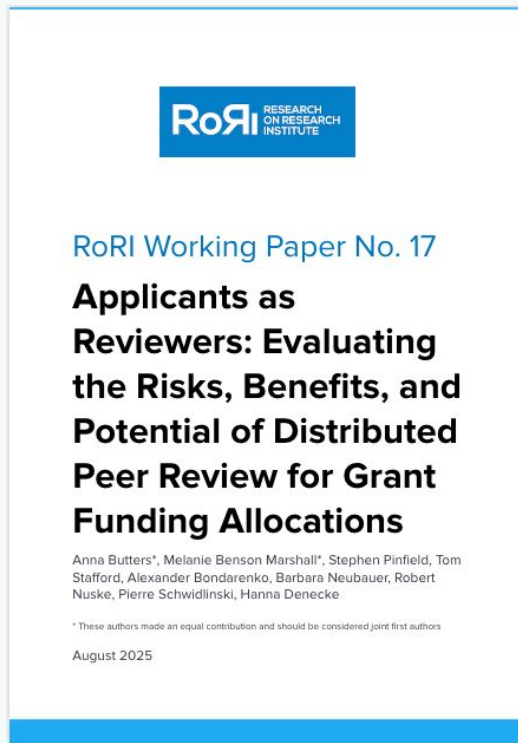
Conclusions



- Comparison between two processes is challenging; conventional system seen as 'tried and tested'
 - Avoid considering familiar systems as normative; recognise both have trade-offs
- Implications for peer review more widely:
 - Reflects the different functions of peer review
 - From the 'wisdom of the gatekeeper' to the 'wisdom of the (expert) crowd'



<https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.29270534.v1>



<https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.29994841>



<https://doi.org/10.1186/s41073-026-00246-7>

Still to come!



Upcoming reports/papers:

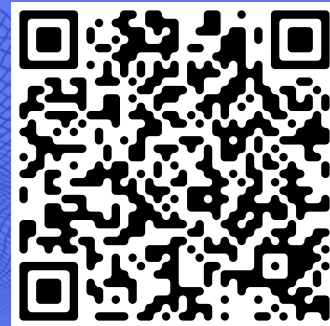
- RoRI Working Paper II: DPR at the Volkswagen Foundation
- DPR as an insight into peer review
- Automated analysis of review comments

Next:

- Comprehensive overview of DPR
 - When, why and how (not) to use
 - Informed by the Volkswagen Foundation experiments



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Thank you

Tom Safford
t.stafford@researchonresearch.org



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RESERVE SLIDES FOLLOW

(not part of talk)

New work from AFIRE

Bingo! Partial Randomisation for emergency research grants

How RoRI helped the Science Philanthropy Alliance with a funding conundrum



TOM STAFFORD
MAR 25, 2026



10



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Share



<https://researchonresearchinstitute.substack.com/>

RoRI RESEARCH
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RoRI Summary note

Demand management: findings from a multi-funder workshop

Alyson Fox (Wellcome), Tom Stafford, Peter Kolarz (Research on Research Institute)
April 2026

https://rori.figshare.com/articles/report/_b_Demand_management_findings_from_a_multi-funder_workshop_b_/32044422?file=64292685

New projects!

- Desk rejection
- EFFORT
- Researcher attitudes to funder experimentation
- Understanding DPR
- Agentic AI and funding

We can plan/run experiments



AFIRE:

t.stafford@researchonresearch.org

josie.coburn@ucl.ac.uk

The experimental research funder's handbook (Revised edition, June 2022, ISBN 978-1-7397102-0-0).

<https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.19459328.v2>

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THE FUTURE OF PEER REVIEW

A system-wide perspective

Stephen Pinfield, Ludo Waltman, Peter Kolarz,
Kathleen Gregory, André Brasil

The Future of Peer Review:
A system-wide perspective
<https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.32685351>